

Case Study I

Role of Media and Communication in Social and Cultural Change in Nepal

Abstract

This case study examines the transformative impact of technology, media, and communication advancements on Nepali society and culture in the 20th century. With the advent of social media, widespread internet access, and mobile technology, traditional communication norms have evolved significantly. These changes have influenced social interactions, cultural practices, and even religious ceremonies in Nepal.

The study highlights both positive outcomes, such as enhanced cultural visibility and connectivity, and challenges, including misinformation and diminished face-to-face interactions. By promoting digital literacy and ethical online behavior, Nepal can navigate these challenges and leverage technological advancements to preserve its cultural heritage.

The findings suggest that a collaborative effort between government, educational institutions, and communities is essential for fostering inclusive growth and maintaining cultural identity in the digital age.

Keywords:

Technology, Social Media, Nepali Society, Cultural Change, Digital Literacy, Communication, Globalization, Media Impact, Cultural Heritage, Misinformation, Digital Inclusion, Technological Advancements

Objectives

In the 20th century with modernization and globalization worldwide, the changes or the ripple effect of technology and social media on society and communities cannot be ignored. The study of social and cultural change is significant in understanding, predicting, and analyzing where the current world, country, community, and cultural practices stand.

In this case study, we will briefly discuss the findings and summarize how technology innovations, media, availability of communication, and access to IT resources have affected Nepali Society and culture — also some possible solutions, and predictions of society's growth.

Introduction

In the 20th century, when modernization and globalization began to spread, new technologies changed the way people communicate all around the world. Nepal was no exception. With the rise of technology, social media, and easier access to information, Nepali society and culture went through some big changes.

This case study looks at how media and communication have influenced Nepali society and culture. We will explore how technology, digital media, and communication have transformed

Nepal. By looking at the findings, we hope to understand how technology is affecting Nepal and what we can do about it.

Findings

In the context of Nepal, back in the days when there was no or very little access to social media like Facebook, YouTube, Instagram, and other internet access, the typical conversation between the people living in a typical Nepali society was not the same as today. Even the late 70s and 80s generation of Nepalese are most likely to gossip and chat on the content of social media today.

The younger generation of modern mothers themselves create personal social media accounts for their children, posting videos, reels, and images of their child's milestones. There was a tradition of keeping a digital photo frame of a newborn child at home, but now newly born child pictures can be instantly captured, uploaded, and shared publicly on the internet.

During and after the COVID-19 pandemic, social media apps like Messenger, Viber, and WhatsApp are widely used to perform small to big Hindu religious events like Puja, Bhaitika, and Dashain Tika, and even to take blessings from senior citizens and relatives. An app like Hamropatro provides services like Jyotish, Kundalini, and online horoscopes, showing how Hindu cultural practices are being digitalized.

Korean dramas, Japanese anime, and Western lifestyles have brought a huge impact on youth and teenagers. From radio to mobile device transformation — having a radio and television was once a sign of luxury, but now even older generation people have access to and are using mobile phones.

There are very few postal services in Nepal, which were once the most important medium to receive and send messages. Now people even in the same room may not have proper open-ended conversations, showing that our friendly culture of sharing stories is slowly diminishing.

On the positive side, cultural events, festivals, and dress are shared, visualized, and promoted via social media. Communities like the Newari celebrate Bisket and Indra Jatra, and festivals like Mahashivaratri and Eid are widely shared. Religious and holy books are also being digitalized through mobile applications.

Discussion

The findings underscore the profound impact of technology and media on Nepali society and culture. Social media platforms have revolutionized communication, altered conversational norms, and enabled widespread sharing of information. However, concerns regarding misinformation and shifts in traditional communication patterns have arisen.

To address these challenges, promoting digital literacy and critical thinking skills is crucial. Educating individuals, especially the youth, on how to discern credible information from misinformation can mitigate the negative effects of social media.

Looking ahead, Nepal is poised to experience further societal and cultural changes as technology continues to evolve. Embracing these changes while safeguarding cultural heritage will require a collaborative effort between government, educational institutions, and communities.

Conclusion

In conclusion, the rapid evolution of media and communication technologies has profoundly influenced the social and cultural dynamics of Nepali society. From the emergence of social media platforms to the widespread adoption of mobile devices, technology has reshaped the way individuals interact, communicate, and engage with cultural practices.

While the digital age has brought about both positive and negative changes, including increased connectivity and cultural exchange, it has also posed challenges such as misinformation and the digital divide. Moving forward, Nepali society must adapt to the digital landscape while preserving its cultural heritage and values.

The case study is mostly structured from limited observation, reflection, and changes in current society, so it may require more in-depth study and revision.

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Case Study II

Innovation and Diffusion in Nepali Society

Abstract

This case study explores the process of innovation and diffusion — how new ideas, technologies, and practices spread across Nepali society. Drawing on Everett Rogers' Diffusion of Innovations theory, the study examines how technological advancements such as mobile banking, digital agriculture tools, and e-governance have been adopted at different rates across urban and rural Nepal.

The study identifies key factors that either accelerate or hinder the adoption of innovation, including social networks, literacy levels, economic status, and cultural compatibility. It highlights both successful examples of diffusion and areas where adoption remains slow, offering recommendations for policy and community-level action to bridge the innovation gap.

Keywords:

Innovation, Diffusion, Technology Adoption, Nepal, Rural Development, Digital Inclusion, Rogers' Theory, Mobile Banking, E-Governance, Change Agents

Objectives

To analyze how innovations — both technological and social — spread through Nepali communities.

To identify the factors that promote or hinder innovation diffusion in Nepal, particularly in rural and marginalized communities.

To provide recommendations for accelerating inclusive innovation adoption in Nepal.

Introduction

Innovation is a cornerstone of social and economic progress. In Nepal, a country undergoing rapid modernization, the diffusion of new ideas and technologies represents both a challenge and an opportunity. From the adoption of improved agricultural practices to the spread of mobile technology, Nepal presents a rich landscape for studying innovation diffusion.

Everett Rogers' Diffusion of Innovations (1962) framework provides a useful lens: innovations spread through a social system over time, and adopters can be categorized as innovators, early adopters, early majority, late majority, and laggards. Nepal's diverse geographic, linguistic, and economic landscape means that diffusion follows uneven patterns — often reaching urban centers first and spreading slowly to rural areas.

Findings

Mobile banking and digital payment systems such as eSewa and Khalti have rapidly diffused among urban youth and educated populations. However, adoption in rural communities remains low due to limited smartphone access, internet connectivity, and digital literacy.

In agriculture, innovations like improved seed varieties, drip irrigation, and digital market platforms have been introduced by government agencies and NGOs. Farmers who have access to extension workers or are part of cooperatives adopt these innovations faster, reflecting the role of change agents and social networks in the diffusion process.

E-governance initiatives such as online tax filing and digital identity (Smart ID cards) have seen uneven diffusion. Urban citizens with internet access and formal employment have benefited, while rural and elderly populations continue to face barriers.

Radio and community FM stations have historically served as important diffusion channels in Nepal, especially for reaching rural areas. These traditional media channels remain relevant even in the digital era, particularly for agricultural, health, and disaster-related information.

Cultural compatibility plays a key role in adoption. Innovations that align with existing cultural practices — such as digital versions of traditional savings groups (dhikuti) or online horoscope services — have been adopted more readily than those perceived as culturally foreign.

Language is also a significant barrier. Most digital innovations are available in Nepali or English, excluding large portions of the population who speak indigenous languages such as Tamang, Magar, Maithili, or Tharu.

Discussion

The uneven diffusion of innovation in Nepal reflects broader structural inequalities — geographic isolation, economic disparity, gender inequality, and linguistic diversity all shape who benefits from new ideas and technologies. Bridging these gaps requires targeted strategies.

Change agents — such as local community health workers, agricultural extension officers, and school teachers — play a crucial role in facilitating diffusion. Empowering these agents with training and resources can accelerate adoption in underserved communities.

Innovation diffusion is not purely a technical challenge but also a social and cultural one. Successful diffusion requires understanding the values, norms, and communication habits of the target community, and tailoring the innovation or its presentation accordingly.

Conclusion

Innovation and diffusion in Nepal are shaped by a complex interplay of technological, social, cultural, and structural forces. While urban areas and educated populations have benefited significantly from new innovations, rural and marginalized communities remain largely excluded.

A more equitable diffusion of innovation requires systemic investment in infrastructure (internet, electricity), culturally sensitive communication strategies, and the empowerment of local change agents. Nepal's development trajectory depends not only on creating or importing innovations, but on ensuring they reach and benefit all segments of society.

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Case Study III

Resistance to Social Change in Nepal

Abstract

This case study investigates the phenomenon of resistance to social change in Nepal, exploring why certain communities, groups, and individuals resist new ideas, technologies, and social reforms. Despite significant progress in education, urbanization, and technology access, many deeply entrenched social practices persist — including caste discrimination, gender inequality, child marriage, and superstitions.

The study examines the social, cultural, psychological, and structural roots of resistance to change, and discusses strategies that have proven effective in overcoming these barriers. It draws on examples from within Nepal and broader sociological theory to offer a nuanced understanding of why change is often slow, contested, and uneven.

Keywords:

Social Change, Resistance, Caste System, Gender Inequality, Cultural Norms, Nepal, Social Reform, Tradition, Modernization, Community Mobilization

Objectives

To identify the major forms and sources of resistance to social change in Nepal.

To analyze the social, cultural, and structural factors that sustain resistance to change.

To evaluate strategies that have been effective in facilitating progressive social change in Nepal.

Introduction

Social change refers to alterations in social institutions, norms, values, and structures over time. While change is an inevitable feature of any society, the pace and direction of change vary significantly depending on the degree of resistance encountered. In Nepal, a country with extraordinary ethnic, linguistic, caste, and regional diversity, resistance to social change is a multifaceted issue.

Nepal has undertaken significant social reforms in recent decades — abolishing the feudal monarchy, enshrining gender equality and caste equality in the 2015 Constitution, and investing in education and healthcare. Yet, formal legal changes have not always translated into shifts in day-to-day social practice. Understanding why requires a careful analysis of the roots of resistance to change.

Findings

Caste-based discrimination remains one of the most persistent forms of social resistance in Nepal. Despite legal abolition, the practice of untouchability continues in many rural areas, particularly in

the hills and Terai. Dalit communities face discrimination in access to water, temples, restaurants, and intermarriage, reflecting deeply internalized social hierarchies that resist formal legal change.

Gender inequality and the resistance to women's empowerment are also significant. Practices such as Chhaupadi (menstrual seclusion), child marriage, and restrictions on women's freedom of movement persist in many communities, particularly in western Nepal. These practices are upheld by community elders, religious leaders, and even some women themselves who have internalized these norms.

Resistance to change often comes from community and religious leaders who fear that social change will undermine their authority and erode cultural or religious traditions. In some communities, adopting new practices such as family planning or girls' education has been framed as a threat to cultural identity.

Economic factors also fuel resistance. In poor households, children's labor is economically important, making child labor and early marriage economically rational in the short term, even when families are aware of the long-term costs.

Political resistance also plays a role. Certain political factions and interest groups resist changes to land reform, federalism, and indigenous rights as these threaten existing power structures.

However, there are also examples of successful change. Community-based organizations, women's savings groups (VSLA), and school-based programs have successfully challenged harmful practices in many districts. Trained female community health volunteers (FCHVs) have been particularly effective change agents, working within communities to shift norms around reproductive health and child nutrition.

Discussion

Resistance to social change is not irrational — it often reflects people's attempts to protect what is meaningful, familiar, and economically or socially useful to them. Effective strategies for change must acknowledge this and work with, rather than against, community values.

Top-down, externally imposed change tends to generate the most resistance, particularly when it fails to engage community leaders and members. Participatory approaches that involve communities in designing and implementing reforms have proven more successful.

Media, particularly radio and community FM stations, have played a positive role in shifting social norms in Nepal — through drama, storytelling, and discussions that make social change feel relatable and desirable, rather than threatening.

Conclusion

Resistance to social change in Nepal is deeply rooted in historical, economic, cultural, and structural factors. Progress has been made in many areas, but significant challenges remain — particularly in addressing caste discrimination, gender inequality, and superstition-based practices.

Sustainable social change requires long-term investment in education, community-based mobilization, economic empowerment, and culturally sensitive communication. The law alone cannot change minds; meaningful transformation requires engaging hearts, communities, and lived

realities.

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Technological Change and Its Consequences in Nepal

Abstract

This case study examines the consequences of rapid technological change in Nepal, focusing on how advancements in information and communication technology (ICT), energy, transportation, and agriculture have reshaped the country's social, economic, and environmental landscape. While technology has brought undeniable benefits — improved healthcare, better market access, enhanced education, and greater connectivity — it has also introduced new challenges including unemployment in traditional sectors, environmental degradation, digital inequality, and cultural disruption.

The study explores these consequences through concrete Nepali examples and proposes a balanced framework for technological development that maximizes benefits while mitigating harms.

Keywords:

Technological Change, ICT, Nepal, Digital Divide, Agriculture Technology, Environmental Impact, Employment, Urbanization, Hydropower, E-Commerce

Objectives

To examine the major dimensions of technological change in Nepal across key sectors.

To analyze both positive and negative consequences of technological change on Nepali society.

To propose strategies for harnessing technology for equitable and sustainable development in Nepal.

Introduction

Nepal is a country of contrasts: ancient temples and cutting-edge hydropower plants, traditional farming communities and booming IT startups, remote mountain villages and hyperconnected urban centers. In recent decades, Nepal has experienced rapid technological change driven by globalization, foreign investment, diaspora connections, and government initiatives.

Technological change refers to improvements in the methods and tools used to produce goods and services, as well as changes in the way people communicate, access information, and conduct daily life. The consequences of such changes are wide-ranging and not always predictable — transforming economies, reshaping social relationships, and altering cultural practices in profound ways.

Findings

The expansion of mobile technology and internet connectivity has transformed commerce, education, and governance. E-commerce platforms, mobile banking (eSewa, Khalti, ConnectIPS),

and online learning have created new economic opportunities, particularly for urban youth. The COVID-19 pandemic accelerated this shift, forcing schools, offices, and businesses to go digital.

In agriculture, new technologies such as improved seed varieties, chemical fertilizers, pesticides, and irrigation systems have increased crop yields. However, they have also led to soil degradation, water contamination, and increased farmer debt. The introduction of mechanized farming in the Terai has displaced agricultural laborers, contributing to rural-urban migration.

Nepal's hydropower potential is enormous — estimated at over 83,000 MW — and investment in hydropower has brought electricity to many communities that were previously without power. Electrification has improved quality of life, enabled small industries, and reduced dependence on firewood, thereby alleviating pressure on forests. However, large-scale hydropower projects have also displaced communities, disrupted river ecosystems, and raised social conflict.

The transportation revolution — including road construction in previously isolated districts, the growth of domestic aviation, and electric vehicles — has increased mobility and market integration. However, rapid road construction without adequate environmental planning has led to landslides, deforestation, and disruption of traditional trade routes.

The rise of digital technology has also created a significant digital divide. Urban, educated, and economically privileged Nepalis benefit disproportionately from technological advances, while rural, elderly, women, and economically marginalized communities are often excluded.

Social media and smartphones have changed the nature of work, particularly in the service and creative industries. New employment categories — social media influencers, app developers, online tutors, content creators — have emerged, while traditional occupations like postal workers, print journalists, and brick-and-mortar retailers have declined.

Discussion

The consequences of technological change in Nepal reflect a broader global pattern: technology is not inherently positive or negative, but its impacts are shaped by who controls it, who has access to it, and what policies govern its development and use.

Nepal needs a strategic approach to technology that ensures equitable access, particularly for rural, female, elderly, and Dalit/Janajati communities. Investment in digital infrastructure, education, and locally relevant content is critical.

Environmental consequences of technological change — from hydropower to road construction to e-waste — require stronger regulatory frameworks and community participation in decision-making. Sustainable technology development must balance growth with environmental stewardship.

Conclusion

Technological change is reshaping Nepal at an unprecedented pace. It is creating new opportunities for economic growth, social mobility, and cultural expression, while simultaneously posing new risks to employment, the environment, social equity, and cultural heritage.

Nepal's challenge is to harness the benefits of technological change while proactively managing its consequences. This requires inclusive governance, investment in human capital, and policies that ensure technology serves the many, not just the few.

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Role of National and International Community in Development of Nepal

Abstract

This case study examines the role played by national institutions and international organizations in Nepal's development trajectory. Nepal is one of the least developed countries in Asia, and its development process has been deeply shaped by both domestic actors — including the government, civil society, and local communities — and international actors such as the United Nations, World Bank, INGOs, bilateral donors, and the Nepali diaspora.

The study analyzes the nature, scope, and effectiveness of these contributions, highlighting successes in areas such as poverty reduction, health, and education, while also critically examining the challenges of aid dependency, coordination failures, and the gap between policy and practice. It ultimately argues that sustainable development in Nepal requires strengthening national ownership while fostering equitable international partnerships.

Keywords:

Development, Nepal, International Aid, Civil Society, INGO, Diaspora, Government, Poverty Reduction, Foreign Aid, National Development, SDGs, Aid Dependency

Objectives

To examine the contributions of national and international actors to Nepal's development.

To critically analyze the effectiveness and limitations of development interventions.

To propose recommendations for a more equitable and nationally owned development model for Nepal.

Introduction

Nepal's development story is complex. Despite significant progress in indicators such as life expectancy, literacy, and poverty rates over the past three decades, Nepal continues to face serious development challenges including poverty, inequality, climate vulnerability, and post-conflict social reconstruction.

Nepal's development is shaped by both internal and external forces. Internally, the federal government, provincial governments, local governments, civil society organizations, and local communities all play important roles. Externally, Nepal receives substantial development assistance from bilateral donors (India, China, USA, UK, EU), multilateral organizations (UN, World Bank, ADB), and international NGOs. The Nepali diaspora — primarily in India, the Gulf, Malaysia, and Western countries — also sends remittances that have become one of Nepal's most important sources of income.

Findings

National government role: Nepal's federal, provincial, and local governments are the primary drivers of development policy. The periodic plans (currently the 16th Plan) set national priorities, and local governments under the 2017 Local Government Operation Act have been empowered to plan and implement development projects in education, health, infrastructure, and social welfare. However, implementation capacity, corruption, and coordination between levels of government remain challenges.

Civil society organizations (CSOs) have played a vital role in advocacy, community mobilization, and service delivery — particularly in areas where the state is absent or weak. Women's rights organizations, Dalit rights groups, indigenous peoples' organizations, and environmental NGOs have been important voices for marginalized communities.

International aid: Nepal is one of the largest per-capita recipients of foreign aid in South Asia. The UN system — through agencies like UNICEF, WHO, WFP, UNFPA, and UNDP — provides technical assistance and funding in health, education, nutrition, and governance. The World Bank and ADB finance large infrastructure and social protection programs.

India plays a particularly complex role in Nepal's development given the two countries' shared open border, cultural ties, and economic interdependence. China's Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) has introduced new investment opportunities but also raised questions about debt sustainability and sovereignty.

The Nepali diaspora sent approximately USD 9 billion in remittances in 2023, equivalent to nearly 25% of GDP — making it the single largest source of external finance. Remittances have lifted many households out of poverty, funded children's education, and financed construction, though they also raise concerns about brain drain and economic dependency.

Post-earthquake reconstruction (2015) demonstrated both the strengths and weaknesses of international aid coordination. While billions of dollars were pledged, implementation was slow due to bureaucratic delays, coordination failures, and lack of community participation. The National Reconstruction Authority (NRA), with international support, eventually oversaw substantial reconstruction, but many lessons remain for future disaster response.

The Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) framework has provided a global structure for aligning national and international development efforts. Nepal has made strong progress on SDG 1 (No Poverty), SDG 3 (Good Health), and SDG 4 (Quality Education), though challenges remain in SDG 5 (Gender Equality), SDG 10 (Reduced Inequalities), and SDG 13 (Climate Action).

Discussion

The relationship between national actors and international development partners in Nepal has evolved over time. Earlier models of aid were largely top-down, with donors setting priorities and national institutions implementing projects with limited ownership. More recent approaches — informed by the Paris Declaration on Aid Effectiveness and subsequent frameworks — emphasize national ownership, alignment with national plans, and mutual accountability.

However, aid dependency remains a concern. When external funding shapes government priorities, there is a risk that national development plans reflect donor interests rather than citizen needs. Strengthening domestic resource mobilization — through improved tax collection, reduction of capital flight, and productive investment of remittances — is essential for reducing dependence on aid.

Coordination among the many actors in Nepal's development landscape remains a persistent challenge. Overlapping mandates, competition for visibility, and inadequate information sharing can undermine effectiveness. The Development Cooperation Policy (2019) provides a framework for better coordination but requires stronger political will and institutional capacity to implement.

Conclusion

The development of Nepal is a shared responsibility — one that requires strong national leadership and ownership, equitable international partnerships, and active engagement of communities. Progress has been significant in many areas, but much remains to be done to ensure that development benefits reach the most marginalized.

Going forward, Nepal must strengthen its institutions, improve transparency and accountability, and leverage the energy and resources of its diaspora and civil society. International partners must shift from aid dependency to genuine partnership — supporting Nepal's own development vision rather than imposing external priorities.

Ultimately, Nepal's development success will depend on whether national and international actors can align their efforts around a shared vision of a just, inclusive, and sustainable Nepal — one that honors its rich cultural heritage while embracing the opportunities of the 21st century.

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